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Author(s): Robert B. Everhart and Wayne J. Doyle

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# The Symbolic Aspects of Educational Innovation<sup>1</sup>

Robert B. Everhart\* and Wayne J. Doyle\*\*

*This paper examines educational innovations in their symbolic aspect—the degree to which innovations convey meanings that differ from their ostensible purpose and the degree to which such other meanings are understood by participants. Using the concepts of slogans and slogan systems to better understand these symbolic aspects, a particular educational innovation is examined over its life history. The organization and use of slogans is discussed, followed by an examination of the evolution of slogan systems. The utility of this perspective is discussed vis à vis parallel concepts in other areas of social policy. INNOVATION AND CHANGE, SYMBOLS, SLOGAN SYSTEMS.*

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Educational change and innovation is a topic still on the minds of many educators despite the shrinking enrollment and resource base facing public educational systems. True, the rhetoric of unbounded optimism that foresaw no limits to what innovative programs could achieve has been replaced in part by the realities of unfulfilled promises and public ambivalence about education. Yet there still remains an ethos about change—one that supports new directions and new attempts at gaining knowledge and assessing those gains. Even in the return to the “basics,” programs are touted as “new” ways of dealing with subject matter or student behavior when, in many cases, these “new” ways simply are reversions to older techniques.<sup>2</sup> In American education, the practices of the past have a way of being translated into new programs for the future. Regardless of the approach, change in our culture, like small, is beautiful.

The application of the ethos of change to educational practice signals a parallel interest among those in the research community. Even with but a cursory review of the literature, it is clear that researchers of all interests—anthropologists, educational psychologists, reading specialists, those interested in schools as organizations—regularly study educational innovation. Yet the majority of such research efforts focus on the intended outcomes of the change effort—that is, the degree to which the program meets the predefined established objectives or, if such objectives were not met, an explanation of why.<sup>3</sup> Such a focus, however, has limitations because it presupposes that these educational changes are meaningful only in relation to the intended and official outcomes of the program. In reality, however, educational programs often take on meanings that differ from their manifest intentions, assuming a

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\*Graduate School of Education  
University of California  
Santa Barbara, California 93106

\*\*School of Education  
University of San Francisco  
San Francisco, California 94117

life of their own generated around the meaning(s) ascribed to them by those with whom those programs come in contact (Everhart 1977; Greenfield 1973). In this sense, any educational change/innovation is more than a program to educate learners. It also is a social phenomenon created by participants.

To the degree that innovations convey meanings that differ from their ostensible purpose, the innovations have a *symbolic aspect*. The meaning of a symbol is not inherent in the fact, object, or behavior, but is derived from the understanding by a group as to what the fact, object, or behavior represents. This understanding is not a static condition but constantly shifts and is redefined by multiple factors. Turner (1974:13) notes the developmental history of the symbolic aspects of phenomena when he notes:

actions of various kinds acquire forms through metaphors and paradigms in actors' heads . . . and, in certain intensive circumstances generate unprecedented forms that bequeath history new metaphors and paradigms.

An educational innovation has a symbolic aspect if its importance lies behind the official/public doctrine of the innovation itself and rests in its meaning to various parties. If the symbolic aspects are more important than the manifestly intended purposes and if the participants' actions central to the innovation reflect primarily symbolic behavior, then the innovation serves a largely *ceremonial* function. An innovation serving a largely *non-ceremonial* function, on the other hand, has a meaning system commensurate with the manifest purposes of the innovation.

How do we know which of these functions an innovation serves? Raymond Firth (1973) tells about a fieldworker in an Asian country who witnessed a group of natives killing a bull; the fieldworker questioned whether the killing was symbolic or done primarily to produce meat. To answer this question, he checked various dimensions of the slaughtering—who was present or absent, their attire, their actions, their discussions, songs, and other activity forms both verbal and non-verbal. He found that the participants did not kill the bull for food; rather the importance of the ceremony rested on its sacrificial dimensions—that is, on the fact that its purpose was to offer a sacrifice for religious purposes.

Firth discovered this primarily through analysis of verbal statements referring to a desired end and the relationship between that end and the activities proposed or thought to bring it about. In the example above such verbal statements may have been in the form of a means-ends statement such as “we drink the blood of the bull so that the gods may be pleased and look favorably upon us.” Here is a desired end (the gods' favorable treatment) and an activity said to bring it about (the drinking of blood). Such statements pertinent to the meaning of a phenomenon are termed slogans, and because they play a critical role in the symbolic aspects of not only ceremonies but change programs as well, their structure and function deserve further elaboration.

Slogans are distinctive phrases or mottos meant to refer to characteristics of a group or a cause. These phrases, valuative in content and often in propositional form, are not scientific propositions as such because they are not subject to scientific refutation (Apple 1975). Thus, a slogan might read “if

you want X, then do Y" while a scientific proposition would read, "if X then Y." A slogan then is a *prescriptive* statement based upon beliefs and meaning whereas a proposition is a *descriptive* statement based upon facts. Slogans make inferences about how present reality might or should be; propositions are grounded in present reality.

Slogans, as McClellan and Komisar (1961) tell us, have both ceremonial and non-ceremonial functions: the former serve to arouse feelings and emotions and the latter provide direction and information. While slogans in education can serve either purpose, often they serve both functions simultaneously. For example, the slogan "children should be involved in decisions about their own learning in school settings" serves both to arouse feelings as well as to explain in a general manner what the thrust of a particular innovation is at a given point in time. To be useful for non-ceremonial purposes, any slogan must be general enough to attract attention yet specific enough to provide direction. It is well known, however, that usually slogans are too general and fail to command the loyalty of those for whom they were intended. These slogans fade away and the phenomena to which they are attached may not survive. Others survive, are enhanced, and capture the imagination of both those in the system and new recruits. These slogans are modified and join the mainstream of other slogans invented to serve some particular purpose.

Slogans usually do not exist in isolated fashion but rather in a loosely related chain composed of similar slogans, all of which focus on some general desired end. These related slogans constitute a *slogan system*. It matters little whether the slogans serve a ceremonial or non-ceremonial function, for as long as the slogans buttress or inform some central cause or ideal, then those related slogans will constitute a system regardless of whether that ideal is reached.

We propose that innovations can be analyzed fruitfully in terms of their symbolic aspects—their ceremonial versus non-ceremonial functions. One manner of examining the ceremonial function of innovations (and thus their symbolic aspect) is to study individual slogans and the systems into which they are organized. An analysis of slogans allows us to unravel the multitudinous fibers of an innovation and to understand better the composition, origin, and purpose of each fiber. In Firth's terms, an analysis of slogans can help clarify whether the innovation uses the bull as meat or as a beast around which an elaborate ceremony with pre-defined rites is ordered.

This paper examines the symbolic aspects of one educational innovation. This particular innovation was a five-year Experimental Schools Project (ESP) funded by the National Institute of Education (NIE), and characterized particularly by the responsibility placed on the local school district to develop, implement, and evaluate its own program with little direction or monitoring from the federal agency (Doyle et al. 1976). Specific aspects of the project are discussed throughout the remainder of the paper.

Our argument about the symbolic aspects of innovations is derived from an analysis of slogans and slogan systems, based upon four years of fieldwork by four fieldworkers. Information recorded in fieldnotes was obtained both as a result of the fieldworkers' presence in or access to public forums (school-

district-community meetings, statements made by school personnel to persons other than the fieldworker, official documents) and from private sources (primarily interviews and personal documents). The centrality of specific slogans emerged about half-way through the study, and consequently we were able to test somewhat systematically over time our theories about their development. Predominant slogans as discussed in this paper are those that were publicly proclaimed and/or maintained over time and which were used by district officials both for explanatory and pragmatic ends.

In the remainder of the paper we discuss the evolution of slogans and their ultimate ceremonial function in Jefferson, a school district of 8,000 students located in a working class community. First, we will explain the slogan system used by the district to operationalize the goal of comprehensive change, centering on the locally developed slogan "providing an appropriate environment for learning for each student." We then trace the history of specific slogans in three main areas which the ESP was to affect: community, organizational relationships, and instruction. Next, we explain how the dynamic history of these slogans can be linked to specific internal and external events that influenced their shifting pattern. Of particular note was the shift of slogans from an emphasis on the integration of organizational units to slogans legitimating the autonomy of those same units. Finally, we assess the project in terms of its symbolic aspects and indicate the uses to which the slogans used in the project were put.

### **Origins of the ESP in the Jefferson District**

The ESP, originally a USOE project but transferred to NIE the following year, was based on the premise that past educational changes had failed because they dealt with isolated aspects of the learning environment (teaching style, instructional strategies, curricular modes), one at a time. ESP was to provide a variety of mutually reinforcing approaches so as to produce a "synergistic" state (for example, simultaneous changes in organization and instruction). This mode, entitled "comprehensive change," was to be implemented in the eighteen ESP sites nationwide.<sup>4</sup>

Through announcements, USOE invited thousands of school districts to apply. The Jefferson district applied for an ESP grant early in January of 1971, the first year of the program, and by February of 1971 Jefferson was one of eight finalists awarded 60-day planning grants. A final proposal was submitted and the award of slightly less than 2.5 million dollars was made to Jefferson in May, 1971. The program was to be operational in September and was to involve six of the district schools for the first two years and all thirteen schools for the last three years of the project.

The proposed project was multi-faceted, but emphasized an alteration of instructional activities. These instructional activities, to be changed district-wide and at all grade levels, centered around a variety of "individualized" and "personalized" curricula deemed useful for meeting an array of pre-defined student needs such as those of "experiencing success," "developing real responsibility," "building a positive self-image," and using student interests "as vehicles for learning." These programs originally were devised to assist the

large number of “transient” students in the district, those whose families were mobile due to work in nearby construction and military installations. To facilitate such instructional changes, certain organizational changes were planned, including a four-day school week with an optional fifth day for experience, vocational and athletic activities, as well as an extended school day to allow for more diverse scheduling possibilities.

Changes were planned in the relationship between the school system and the community as well. The families in the Jefferson district were largely working class, and the income level of Jefferson families was slightly less than the average national family income. Though the district had the lowest assessed valuation of any comparably sized district in the state, voter approval of local excess levy elections had been consistent. Jefferson officials were vague about how they planned to alter the involvement of the community in the affairs of the school, but envisioned that community members would be intensely involved in the planning and actual operation of ESP activities. The district also proposed that community resources be used more extensively for educational purposes. While the mechanism for accomplishing this was unclear in the beginning, the fact that community involvement was to be part of the ESP suggested some activity in this area.

District administration and organization was a final area wherein changes were to be made. The superintendent, designated originally as the ESP director, was to spend 20 percent of his time on project activities. Additionally, a full-time executive director was assigned to manage project affairs, especially those instructionally related. Numerous other project positions were created, including a Director of Evaluation (to design ways of measuring the impact of the project on the achievement of students), a Director of Environmental Education (to operate the district’s Environmental Education program, considered to be a major new instructional focus), a district “Disseminator” (to develop all project publications), and development specialists (one for each project school) to be responsible for the coordination of individualized programs in each school.

### **Slogans and Their Development**

Through the first two years, the project slogan system addressed the main intent of the project—“implementing comprehensive change throughout the school system”—which spoke to the wide-ranging effects of change that were to be felt in the areas of instruction, community, and organization. While not carefully defined, the notion of comprehensive change, at least as understood by NIE, entailed mutually reinforcing changes that affected all students in the school system. Comprehensive change was to be operationalized by the district through a central slogan—“providing an optimum learning environment for each child”—developed by the district before the project implementation and addressing, from the district’s perspective, the instructional emphasis of the project. Yet comprehensive change came to be variously interpreted and emphasized. New slogans within that system were born over the five years of the project; others died and still others were transformed during this period of time. By analyzing the development of key slogans in the

areas of organization, community, and especially instruction (where the majority of slogans existed), we can gain a better understanding of the dynamics of the ESP in Jefferson and the evolution of the slogan system of comprehensive change.

### *Organization*

The project proposal did not detail any sweeping changes in district administration. Curricular changes were to be implemented within each separate school and district-wide coordination accomplished by both development specialists within each school and the executive director, working in coordination with the superintendent. However, "development specialists" never really existed, and the executive director and superintendent assumed administrative control of the project for the first year. Six months into the project, NIE's impatience grew over what it saw as a lack of progress on the organizational elements of comprehensive change. One project officer from NIE made the following observation in an ESP memorandum:

At the present time, there is no real vertical articulation of programs through high school; nor is there a great deal of substantive coordination among the four elementary schools . . . the staff (NIE) is less concerned that there is no obvious articulation now than by the fact that we don't see the issue of articulation being perceived as a priority for the project.

To NIE's way of thinking, the project was not meant to consist of different activities at different schools, but rather a "continual, logical progression of content and delivery system from kindergarten through grade 12." NIE viewed the organization of the district governance as a central reason why this more integrated approach had not occurred; the fact that the superintendent seemed more concerned with the fiscal aspects of the project than the implications of "comprehensiveness" made the problem especially acute. In order to move toward greater integration, NIE and Jefferson agreed to the creation of an ESP cabinet in which all principals would set policy regarding project objectives. NIE believed that if all building administrators were to confront collectively comprehensive change and resultant "optimum learning environments," the tendency toward autonomous decisions by schools would be reduced.

Tracing the evolution of slogans about the cabinet provides an accurate record of its existence. Slogans attesting to the cabinet's operations were notably absent during the first year of its operation (the second year of the project). The cabinet met bi-monthly for the entire year, and even though the cabinet structure appeared somewhat novel, the district minimized the cabinet in its own rhetoric. There were two reasons for this. First, the idea of the cabinet had been adopted less than enthusiastically by the district, and the superintendent was still unsure of its viability. After all, the cabinet's existence meant his removal as titular head of the project, and it was difficult for him to support a body in which he was assigned the role of an advisor. The principals too were unsure of their roles, as they were unaccustomed to having to consider policy beyond the boundaries of their schools. While much of this

first year was spent negotiating responsibilities, roles, and expectations, NIE had great expectations for the cabinet. Already, various NIE representatives were touting the cabinet idea as a "major experiment in the manner by which schools are governed."

The status of this "major experiment" became most evident toward the end of the first year when a proposal for the second half of the project was prepared for NIE. Preparation of this document was ostensibly the responsibility of the cabinet, as the cabinet's envisioned purpose was to direct district-wide policies affecting all schools. Yet individual cabinet members were not accustomed to viewing the district as a whole, and few had any criteria by which to judge requests for parts of the two million dollars granted to the district. After some deliberation by the cabinet, the superintendent (an *ex-officio* member) presented his own budget which, after subtracting amounts for fixed costs and district overhead expenditures, allocated the remaining money to schools on the basis of enrollment and without regard for the program needs or desires. The cabinet was relieved that the superintendent had assumed his "normal" responsibilities and disbursed funds in such a non-controversial manner. "Now, at least we'll have something to sink our teeth into," said one member. Another agreed: "It is good that someone else besides us makes these big decisions."

Slogans pertaining to the cabinet and its operation became more pronounced and then shifted in emphasis after the project was refunded. First the district, admitting publicly what was obvious by now, minimized the role of the cabinet as a body that would integrate district ESP operations (a role that the district itself never claimed, but rather one for which NIE had hopes) and emphasized a new role for the cabinet as a body which would review the district's current educational program. Secondly, the role of the cabinet as a unifying body was placed in the background as district rhetoric proclaimed that "the heart of the ESP is the individual school; each principal and his staff builds its own approach, its own way of reaching each child," a slogan that came to dominate descriptions of the Jefferson ESP for the remainder of the project. While the cabinet continued to function, district officials perceived it as a forum where administrators "communicate more openly about matters of mutual concern," rather than as an organ of integration and articulation.

Yet if the heart of the ESP was the individual school, the cabinet did play a major role in regulating somewhat disparate activities within those schools. Events of the last three years of the project reveal that, in the process of reviewing district programs, the cabinet had gained sufficient informal power to establish itself as a protectionist body, collectively maximizing the autonomy of the individual schools represented by its members. Especially in the last year of the project, the cabinet took action to ensure minimal disruption from outside. First, they rewrote the mission of the cabinet to include review of all categorically funded projects. In this manner the individual principals, rather than the superintendent alone, could weigh the benefits and costs of external funds and decide whether or not to pursue them. Second, the cabinet managed to have the lump-sum allocation of money to each school increased by \$10 per student, thus providing principals increased financial autonomy



and leverage, not to mention more independence from the superintendent and external sources such as NIE. The availability of these funds greatly facilitated decisions in the third area wherein the cabinet collectively strengthened the power of its members—the decision of which ESP programs to retain after the end of the project. Programs related to “appropriate learning environments” had been selected by schools on an individual basis, and there seemed no reason to use a different method to make decisions on discontinuance. The availability of additional lump-sum funds aided greatly in those decisions.

In the area of governance, then, predominant slogans evolved in two distinct forms, as illustrated in Table 1. First NIE advertised the cabinet as a “major new experiment,” but as the success of this experiment became questionable, neither they nor the district emphasized the cabinet during the last half of the project. It was then that the district picked up its own slogan of each school “building its own approach” and claimed that the cabinet’s existence provided a forum within which individual schools could make collective decisions, respecting at the same time each other’s freedom of choice. As we have discussed, however, those collective decisions focused largely on protecting the prerogatives of the individual schools.

### *Community*

School-community relationships in Jefferson prior to the ESP were typical of those in most districts: the district was arranged hierarchically with a non-partisan Board of Education establishing broad policies and the district superintendent, deputy superintendent, and building principals implementing policy. PTA organizations served as a bridge between parents and the school, although parental involvement was minimal and sporadic.

In its ESP proposal, Jefferson had proposed establishing of a district-wide “charette” as a “regular procedure for converting community desires into real programs.” The charette was to include the participation of the entire community in the conceptualization and operationalization of the project. Here, the community and school professionals were to interact and to “develop a plan that is implementable because of consensus and commitment.” Hopes for the charettes were high, for OE had touted it as a forum that would “carry insurance against rejection by any part of the power structure.” Yet such optimism was not well founded. In the first charette, held in conjunction with the planning grant ostensibly to assist in the development of the project proposal, the main activity consisted of the presentation of project plans conceived by the superintendent and his staff to those in attendance. Earlier, the superintendent had told the Board of Education that the purpose of a charette during the planning phase was to “determine if the community is ready for the changes inherent in the project,” indicating that the major decisions had already been made. Clearly, even in the earliest stages, there appeared to be a considerable hiatus between the rhetoric and reality of the charette.<sup>5</sup>

Similar patterns were evident at the second and third charettes, held during the first year of the ESP. Organized around the rhetoric of broadening

**Table 1.** Overview of Slogans in the Jefferson ESP

|                             | <b>Slogans Present<br/>During First Half of Project</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>Slogans Present During<br/>Last Half of Project</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Central Slogan System       | Implementation of comprehensive change: to provide an optimum learning environment for each child.                                                                                                                                                                                         | Implementation of programs in basic skills, work experience, and the interim. ESP as regional demonstration center.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Organization/<br>Governance | The administrative cabinet is a major experiment in the manner in which schools are governed.                                                                                                                                                                                              | The heart of the ESP is the individual school; each principal and staff builds its own approach.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Community Relations         | The charette is to be a procedure for converting community desires into real programs.<br>The charette will insure against rejection of community input by the district power structure.                                                                                                   | Neighborhood groups are the best source of input into school policy.<br>Each principal knows his own community best.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Instruction                 | Provide appropriate learning environment for each child through: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>● development of real student responsibility</li> <li>● increase in positive self-image</li> <li>● participation by students in programs utilizing their own interests.</li> </ul> | Each school has the freedom to select those programs it decides will allow it to best accomodate objectives.<br>Alternatives mean program activities and teaching methods within an individual school and even within each classroom.<br>Students need to have a good command of basic educational skills. Innovation does not mean better but does mean different than was done before. |

the base of involvement in ESP, the second charette attracted a small audience of community members and evidenced a continued one-way communication flow—the district informing the small number of parents in attendance of what programs had been implemented (or were being considered for implementation). Preparation for the third charette, held in the spring of the first project year, evoked considerable discussion within the district administration about the roles community members could serve, but little was resolved. While attendance increased at the third charette, those in attendance were representatives of the better educated and longer term district residents. In addition, an informal district survey indicated that 70 percent of those in attendance were recruited by building principals. The third charette, consisting of four separate sessions and the most ambitious of all, produced

more active participation but still characteristically unspectacular results. The district survey revealed that 75 percent of those in attendance felt they were not consulted enough about school policy making. Also, parents who had been passive in previous meetings began to voice their opinions. One parent, suspicious of the intent of the charette, questioned "What bearing does this group have on anything?" Others questioned what the group was supposed to accomplish. Attendance dropped over the sessions, and only 20 parents appeared for the last session. A few weeks after the charette, the program cabinet, whose members had viewed the charette with caution and who always had resisted parental involvement in the operation of the schools, voted to abandon the charette as a mechanism for community involvement.

Yet this absence of activity in the area of community involvement could not continue, for the superintendent suggested to the cabinet that NIE surely would apply pressure for a new community forum. Yet cabinet members continued to resist any community-wide forum such as the charette, maintaining, as one principal commented, that "once you start a thing like this, it gets away from you and pretty soon parents want to run the school." The second year of the project showed little activity in the domain of community involvement. However, the advent of refunding toward the end of the second year forced reconsideration of school-community relations. A draft of the refunding proposal written by the superintendent included vaguely worded statements about a community-wide parent advisory forum, but this received less than enthusiastic responses both from principals (one commented, "I thought we had already killed this thing"), and NIE ("the section—of the proposal—does not inspire confidence that the concerns of the community will be represented adequately"). While the superintendent and his close associates labored to devise an acceptable response, the principals quietly were advocating the return to school-based community groups rather than one forum to cover the entire district.

The existence of school-based groups proved to be the ultimate resolution of the issue of community involvement. Called Parent Advisory Councils (PAC), they were proposed as a means of "providing feedback and exchanging information." These councils, one at each of the district's thirteen schools, were to be organized by each principal. No special agendas were proposed, the frequency of meetings was not specified, and the methods of encouraging involvement were not detailed. This mode of community involvement, while originally not acceptable to NIE, eventually was permitted during the latter half of the project for two reasons. First, NIE officials wanted more time to solidify gains made in governance and to ensure the continuation of the cabinet; to do so (according to NIE) would leave little time for concern with community involvement, admittedly of lesser priority. Secondly, NIE knew that the cabinet had resisted district-wide involvement and that its members wished to oversee the role of parents by controlling the PAC at each school. NIE felt that, by giving the principals a "victory" in the area of community involvement, the role and legitimacy of the cabinet would be strengthened, making it more effective in dealing with other more central issues of "comprehensive change."

With the decrease in pressure from NIE to alter school-community

forums, the slogans of community involvement changed from emphasis on the role of community-wide forums to develop and operationalize ESP policy to one of parents gathering “as neighborhood groups to present their ideas to their own school so that schools may provide educational experiences that are realistic within the students’ own community” (see Table 1). In effect, the existence and operation of the PAC returned one phase of the ESP—community involvement—to the school. The slogans invented illustrate that direction. A resurrection of such slogans as “the principals know their own community best,” “with PAC’s, the principals can really keep their finger on their community” and “the principals really know their community” appeared after the creation of PAC’s. Little input on community participation was received from NIE during the last half of the project. The district administration had no desire to encourage community involvement if it was not required, and the principals were satisfied to call their own selectively attended parent meetings three or four times a year. Slogans of neighborhood participation were scarcely needed and rarely heard in the latter part of the project.

### *Curriculum and Instruction*

The area of instruction received, by far, the majority of the district’s attention in terms of time, money, and commitment. The planning grant was awarded on the understanding that the ESP was to focus on children from transient and low-income families who had special and specific needs. While community and governance activities were part of the “comprehensive change” effort, these activities were to be supportive of changes in the instructional process, as the ESP largely was an attempt to alter the instructional environment of the district.

The optimum learning environments outlined in the original proposal were to be many and varied. Regular “reactive” classroom environments (lectures or teacher dominated settings) and “interactive” environments (seminars) were to be supplemented by environments where students took an “active” role or made an active choice in learning mode (for example, resource centers, home television courses, and an increase in laboratory courses). Additionally, the district placed a premium on environmental education, an appreciation for other cultures through international education, and contact with the world of work through work experience. Many activities were to occur within a radically altered schedule wherein schools would be opened until late in the evening each day, permitting a greater variety of courses tailored to the individual students. Since most district families were “working class” with both parents employed and “shift” work common, a liberalized schedule was proposed to permit parents greater opportunity to be home at the same time as their children.

A number of “individualized” educational programs were continued, expanded, or adopted to facilitate instructional choice. Particularly on the elementary level, programs in mathematics, science, language, and reading were seen as providing diversity in student abilities by facilitating increased “diagnostic teaching” whereby teachers, through the results of a pre-test,

could place students at any one of a number of levels; students would remain at that level until they had mastered the material as determined by the results of a post-test.

The largest number of discrete slogans within the slogan system pertaining to optimum learning environments related to instruction. Early district rhetoric stressed an integrated approach to changes in the instructional environment. The stress on individualization, although never made in precise terms in the early days of the project, reiterated the need for flexibility and options available to all district students at all grade levels. To fulfill these expectations, students in the project would "develop real responsibility" (through independent study, contract learning, and required work experience), have an "increased positive self-image" (by taking part in programs suited to the student's rate of advancement and ability rather than courses required of all students at the same time) and "would participate in programs utilizing their own interests as vehicles for learning" (through student designed and initiated courses, courses planned jointly by students and teachers). Tailoring the school experience to the needs of the individual student was an early claim of the ESP, and this approach was to be followed consistently across the district.

The slogans evident in the proposal and in subsequent documents became manifested in diverse ways after the beginning of the project, as each building had wide latitude in its interpretation. The materialization of goals pertaining to the individualization of instruction, student developed curricula, and the manner in which students would develop "real responsibility" all were matters decided by the individual schools, independent (or largely independent) of any orchestrated district policy or procedure.<sup>6</sup> As the first and then the second year of the project passed, the "Balkanization" of instructional activities became clear to the extent that each school, while keeping with the general spirit of ESP curricular adoptions (typically, the purchase of "individualized" curricular packages) was free to use those packages in any manner desired. Schools also were free to maintain most pre-ESP instructional practices.

Other aspects of the proposed instructional plan never began or were reduced in scale. The differentiated staffing plan, attempted (in a modified fashion) in three district elementary schools, encountered stiff resistance due to continued reservations about job security and teacher dissatisfaction with the increase in discipline problems that many attributed to the fluid staff patterns and the resultant inability of teachers to know all the students well. The expanded school day and school year never proceeded beyond the planning stage, in part because of the principals' position that neither the community nor the school staff desired such a plan. Finally, the cross-district environmental education and international education programs meant to provide a coherent and integrated program across all schools, died in their infancy largely as a result of the reluctance of building principals to surrender building resources (funds and/or staff) to a district-wide program.

Yet the curricular and instructional activities that were ongoing spawned a series of new slogans during the second year of the project. Stimulated by the need to obtain refunding, these slogans focused upon a justification of current

activities to provide evidence of perceived instructional strengths. For example, during the second year of the project, the district printed a brochure touting the flexibility of project administrators in selecting programs germane to their clientele and the needs of the community. Therein were proposed slogans that more closely approximated reality. The slogan "each principal and his staff builds its own approach, its own way of reaching each child" became proclaimed widely as a positive dimension of what outsiders often perceived to be fragmented aspects of the project; accordingly, decentralization of the instructional effort became advertised as a positive virtue rather than as a limitation. This slogan was not seen to contradict project objectives, for the alleged advantage to this approach was that "each school has the freedom to select those programs it decides will allow it to best accommodate the objectives."

Although not originally framed as such, individualization of instruction soon was offered as a form of "alternative education." The impetus for this was probably two-fold: first, the rhetoric about alternatives during the early seventies had achieved some currency in Jefferson and the superintendent was interested in staying in the mainstream. Second, and related to this, an ESP in the Midwest emphasized alternatives and NIE informally advertised this program as its most successful project. Anxious for its own program to be favorably compared, and needing to propose a rational model for its loose federation of programs, Jefferson proposed the slogan that alternative education did not necessarily mean having to choose between schools offering different programs. Alternatives, as a Jefferson publication noted, "can mean program activities and teaching methods within an individual school and even within each classroom . . ." Generally speaking then, the presence of multiple textbooks, learning packages, or a combination of teaching methods (small group and large group instruction) constituted, in Jefferson's terminology, a form of "alternative education."

Other slogans appeared during the latter half of the project, displacing slogans present earlier. "Individualized" curricular programs had not been uniformly adopted or favored by most teachers, and as Jefferson's achievement test scores decreased with national averages, individualization either became associated with this decline or at best was perceived to contribute little to higher test scores. The greater emphasis placed "on the need for students to have a good command of basic educational skills," justified the retention of many "basic education" programs as well as legitimated the drastic de-emphasis on individualization present in slogans.

In the meantime, NIE continued its sporadic efforts to discuss with the district the meaning and purposes of the district's instructional efforts. When the project director of NIE visited the district the next to last year of the project, he asked the superintendent to specify exactly what the ESP was to accomplish in Jefferson:

When I go to Metropolis, I know what they're trying to do; it's alternatives. When I go to Midland, I know their concern is articulation between the schools and the minority clientele; when I come to Jefferson, I have a hard time knowing exactly what it is you are doing.

The message was clear, and the day before the project director was to return to Washington the superintendent, at a meeting between NIE and district officials, circulated a one page document he had written to explain the purpose of the ESP. It stated, in part, that the purpose of the ESP was:

to serve as a regional demonstration site for promising curriculum efforts in education which have been developed and validated elsewhere; to develop and install curriculum and manage these programs . . . within or below the prevailing cost of traditional or alternative programs.

Concurrently, the district announced dissemination of a new publication which stated that “while the emphasis of each school may vary somewhat,” the emphasis of the ESP “now falls into . . . basic skills, work experience, and the Interims.” These slogans significantly departed from earlier statements that pointed to a more integrated instructional program.

Additional new slogans were promulgated by the superintendent during the last year of the project. These slogans appeared to anticipate criticisms of the district’s failure to implement many of the projects around which slogans were originated early in the project. For example, with regard to Differentiated Staffing, the superintendent reported that while the district did not adopt the original DS plan, it did adopt a more efficient and useful model, one that he termed “an efficient differentiated staffing model.” Finding fault in the standard DS model as being “top heavy” and “cumbersome”—“something our teachers did not want,”—he emphasized the presence of the efficient DS model, “relying heavily on teacher aides and student volunteers.” He also made public statements that the district was truly innovative in the area of instruction because the district was different than it had been five years earlier. “Innovation does not mean better,” he said, “but usually it does mean different than was done before.”

In summary then, as in the areas of community and governance, we see the existence and invention of slogans in curriculum and instruction to either propose, describe, or defend the practices of the district with regard to the project (see Table 1). While the descriptive use of slogans often accurately described the present state of affairs, it also provided a context which enhanced the image of the district.

The material thus far indicates a *patterning* of slogans over the five-year period. Noting the ebb and flow of their existence, as well as their presence during some periods but not others, we can ask if these slogans appeared haphazardly, or if there was some force(s) or impetus behind their coming and going. That issue is addressed in the next section of the paper.

## **The Life History of Slogan Systems**

### *Slogan Patterns*

As is clear by now, the slogan system, and the slogans comprising that system, present at the beginning of the project usually were not those present at the end. Examination of the Jefferson ESP illustrates that, while the life history of any one slogan or slogan system could vary widely, certain patterns did exist relative to their presence or absence (see Table 2).

Some slogans were *abandoned* at various stages of the project, their existence no longer apparent or useful. A number of these slogans were abandoned early in their life cycle, as was the case with a slogan referring to a main purpose of the ESP as being "to meet the needs of transient and low-income students (who) often lack the stability and emotional tools to relate well to their peer groups." The Jefferson district, located in an area of relatively high unemployment and educating many children from nearby military bases, was characterized by considerable student turnover. Yet, in the proposed emphasis on transiency, the district never demonstrated that these students required resources that differed from those required by the student population in general.<sup>7</sup> Consequently, there was little attempt to identify and "treat" such transient students, and since the slogans associated with transiency had no meaningful referent, they were abandoned at the end of the first year, rarely to be mentioned again.

Two other slogans concerned with environmental and international education were dropped during the second year of the project. Since neither program had been implemented, slogans such as "environmental education will have a maximum impact upon the understanding and interpretation of his environment by the student" and "international education is a way of broadening the student's experiences with other cultures" were abandoned because they referred to non-existent programs.

More common than wholesale abandonment of slogans was the *invention* of new slogans over the duration of the project. Indeed, the more durable slogans were those invented by the district to address particular aspects of project operations. For example, one of the most pervasive slogans in the ESP was that "each principal and his staff builds its own approach, its own way of reaching the child." This slogan was applied to many areas, legitimating, for example, the frequently idiosyncratic choice of curricular material within each school as well as the principals' practice of forming their own parent advisory committees because local control allowed the principals to "best tap the individual talents of parents in each school attendance area." "Alternatives within each school" was another slogan that was invented. This slogan arose midway through the project in response to the popularity of the "alternatives" movement at the time. Unlike the slogan mentioned above, the alternatives theme was used for a short period of time and then only sporadically. Still another slogan invented (and one with a short life-span) was that of the ESP "serving as a regional demonstration center for promising curricular efforts in education." While this slogan was not created until the fourth year of the project, it did receive considerable attention as a way of explaining the district's multitude of seemingly disparate curricular materials. Yet this slogan too died, visible and in use for less than one year during the latter stages of the project.

Most slogans were neither abandoned nor invented but rather *transformed* over the duration of the project. By transformed, we mean that the slogans changed in meaning to fit the exigencies of the time and that, while the essence of the slogan remained the same, the meaning signified by that slogan changed.

The transformation of slogans over time is evident in a few key areas,



Table 2. Overview of Life History of Selected Slogans

| Disposition of Slogans | Nature of Slogan                                                                            | Event(s) that Precipitated Disposition                                                                           |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Abandoned              | ESP designed to meet needs of transient and low income students.                            | Devised as way to target on low income groups. Dropped due to lack of pressure to provide interpretation.        |
|                        | Environmental education as a tool to impact understanding of environment.                   | Dropped due to pressure from funding agency because of non-existent programs.                                    |
|                        | International education to broaden student experiences with other cultures.                 |                                                                                                                  |
| Invention              | Each principal and staff building their own approach.                                       | Justification to funding agency, review panels, and others for fragmented comprehensiveness.                     |
|                        | Alternatives consist of the variety of programs in each school.                             | Desire to appear "current" to interested outside parties and local clients.                                      |
|                        | ESP as regional demonstration center for proven and promising instructional programs.       | Post hoc explanations to funding agency of intent of the program.                                                |
| Transformation         | Individualization of instruction from experimental to experimental delivery systems.        | Public relations created need to define on-going practice as innovative.                                         |
|                        | Differentiated staffing from professional division of labor to use of auxiliary assistance. |                                                                                                                  |
|                        | Innovation as different, not better.                                                        | Need to justify to funding agency and its agents the rationale for continuance of practices meant to be altered. |
|                        | ESP cabinet from major experiment in decision making to making more "decisions."            |                                                                                                                  |

individualization of instruction being one. While individualization of instruction never was explicitly defined in the early stages of the project, a number of conditions established its early parameters. First, a central slogan of the Jefferson ESP, that of "creating an appropriate environment for optimum learning for each student," demanded appropriate diagnostic services in order to identify the learning required for each student. Once an assessment had been made, learning settings to meet those needs were to be established.

A second condition of individualization dealt with the establishment of programs designed for individual students or cohorts of students with similar needs, regardless of the specific school they attended. Emphasis on an altered school calendar, a considerable reduction in the adult-pupil ratio, the use of new programs in programmed instruction, various media and technology, and grouping practices permitting students to pursue interest areas illustrate some of these new programs or arrangements said to facilitate individualization.

However, individualization as originally proclaimed became less predominant in slogans over the project because (a) most principals and their staffs neither understood many of the directions proposed nor favored those they did understand, and (b) the directions proposed, for the most part, were not implemented, and most of what passed for individualization was sporadic. "New" slogans referring to the district's efforts on individualization soon appeared to replace those originally proclaimed. The sporadic individualized approach, obviously less pervasive after the first year of the project than had been proposed, was defended by the superintendent, who shifted the emphasis from programs to "delivery systems" when he said that "most of the programs are not experimental. . . . only the delivery systems we are using are experimental." Also, the school calendar was said to be altered through the addition of a summer school which contributed to "a more efficient use of buildings." Finally, as noted previously, the superintendent had announced that the absence of the Differentiated Staffing (DS) model originally proposed did not necessarily mean the absence of a viable DS program, but rather substitution of an "efficient DS model. . . . which is really a better system than that advocated by the experts." Asked to assess the entire instructional effort after five years, the superintendent claimed it a success on the basis that the district indeed had been changed as a result of the ESP, noting that "innovation does not mean better, but usually it does mean different than was done before."

We see then—through examination of abandonment, invention, and transformation—the association of slogans with educational practice. By and large, changes in slogans came about in order to conform to or legitimate current district practice; consequently, we can say that slogans were altered as a function of the patterns of social/formal organization of the ESP and attendant behaviors. Yet this is not to say that slogans were not also causal in nature—determinant of those same patterns of organization and interaction. For example, evidence abounds that slogans pertaining to individualized instruction as "delivery systems" rather than as radically new procedures for diagnostic teaching helped reinforce, in the minds of teachers, the idea that individualized instruction was little more than the use of commercially prepared learning kits. Equally relevant, the slogans about "each principal and school building its own approach. . . ." served to lead to (as well as justify) autonomous planning in schools. In this sense then, slogans both grew out of ongoing reality and turned to define and re-orient that reality.

### *Precipitators of Slogan Changes*

Every change in a slogan, whether it was abandoned, invented, or transformed, was more than an accidental or random occurrence. Events or series of events,

internal and external to the district, were associated with and usually responsible for changes in slogans. Let us examine these precipitating events, reviewed in Table 2.

The slogan around which the ESP was first proposed, that of meeting "the needs of transient and low income students . . ." was abandoned by the end of the first year because no audience claimed this slogan as particularly meaningful. As noted, district staff had not articulated any special needs for transient students and thus could not see the ESP as a program meant to serve that population. Additionally, OE/NIE subsequently placed little pressure on the district to explain why the issue of transiency was not being addressed. Because transiency-related slogans received no interpretation from either internal or external sources, their early abandonment was not surprising.

The abandonment of slogans dealing with environmental and international education also was precipitated by events external to the district. The environmental education program never had been implemented, leading NIE to insist that the district drop the program from its proposal for the second half of the project. International education suffered the same fate, and slogans about these two programs disappeared.

Invented slogans usually were preceded by requests for explanations about the project from and/or statements about the project by sources external to the district. The slogan of "each principal and his staff builds its own approach, its own way of reaching the child" emerged after numerous informal NIE-sponsored external reviews of the project during the first two project years. Some of these reviews questioned if any progress had been made, as illustrated by a 1972 report that stated, "The ESP, instead of being a continuous, articulated educational experiment, appears to be a series of component parts . . ." Other external reports reflected similar observations. Even a progress report issued by the district itself (although written by an individual obviously not socialized into the technique for writing "progress" reports) stated that "various components . . . appear to be conducting their own separate projects without the coordination necessary for the successful completion of the overall ESP." Such statements had a cumulative effect, and the district could not ignore them forever. Therefore, autonomy and fragmentation, conditions identified in outside as well as internal reports as evidence that the original objectives were not being met, were turned around by the district into conditions indicating an ascending rather than a descending direction, as further illustrated by such slogans as "the success of the ESP perhaps can be laid to the fact that each school made its own decisions about what it would do toward meeting the goals of the project," and the ESP "served as a regional demonstration center for promising curricular efforts in education." In these and other cases, slogans emerged due to the pressure from outside to reconcile rhetoric with reality. The district made this reconciliation by advertising present patterns as intended, thus justifiable.

Input from the funding agency and other external bodies seemed to precipitate the transformation of slogans. Visitors who came to the school district to see the "experimental" project provided another continual impetus for re-definition of many project dimensions. For example, as visitors tactfully noted that individualization was not as novel as advertised, a constant

(although benign) pressure influenced the transformation of slogans about individualization from “experimental programs” to “experimental delivery systems.” The district’s Differentiated Staffing plan was under similar scrutiny, with the presence of aides and volunteers in the classroom hardly fitting the acceptance models of Differentiated Staffing. To handle this dissonance, the superintendent coined the phrase “efficient DS,” to note that the district’s use of aides and volunteers was more cost-effective and had not created the conflict evident in other collaborative efforts.

The ESP participants’ relationships to the slogans varied. On the one hand, the superintendent spawned the greatest percentage of slogans about the ESP. Most teachers knew little about many slogans and consequently they went about their business only slightly affected by the ESP “cause.” Many slogans scarcely touched some administrators who preferred to go about the business of running their schools without being bothered by “innovation,” a situation aptly illustrated after one meeting wherein the superintendent attempted to infect his administrators with ESP by listing all of the activities that should be included in the re-funding document. One principal, upon leaving the meeting, turned to a colleague and said, “I don’t really care for all the jargon; I just want to know when I can order my paper for next year.”

Yet others did become involved and picked up on the use of slogans as a way of pulling together present activities under a rubric linked to “innovation.” In other words, they learned that the invention of slogans provided a convenient link between rhetoric and reality. We remember vividly one meeting between the program cabinet and NIE officials in which the chairman of the cabinet signaled the invention of a slogan to explain “comprehensive change” when he said to the NIE official:

I’ve been trying to get our staff to draw up a big chart showing everything that is happening here with NIE funds. Would that help you? We were told last year [that] we weren’t comprehensive so I want to get something that shows it.

Statements such as “getting something to show it” are illustrative of the degree to which slogans were seen as legitimate devices to match up present practice with NIE objectives. However, we gathered no conclusive evidence to support the position that use of these slogans was a conscious political ploy meant to deceive. Most district officials seemed to genuinely believe that what they were doing fit the guidelines established by NIE. The fact that such a statement as the one above was made before these officials and that it went unchallenged seems to support this conclusion.

By pulling together the evolution of slogans in organization, community, and instruction, we see a distinct shift in the emphasis of slogans from the original intent of the ESP—inter-relatedness and integration of effort throughout all areas of the district—toward a system characterized by unit autonomy, minimal coordination between units, and an emphasis upon commercially prepared instructional packages chosen by each school with little concern for the relationship of those packages to the intent of the ESP. The shift is perhaps best summarized by noting that the central theme of the ESP in the first year was to “institute comprehensive change by providing an optimum learning

environment appropriate for each child.” By the end of the project there was no mention of comprehensiveness, rather, the purpose of the project was stated to be that of serving “as a regional demonstration site for promising curriculum efforts . . .” The evolution of slogans followed a consistent pattern of permitting, legitimating, justifying, or explaining the disparity between prescriptive viewpoints of the ESP and the day-to-day reality of life within the district, a reality only slightly changed by the ESP.

The shift in slogans toward support of particularistic programs illustrates the existence of the ESP as an opportunity for financial aid rather than as a program to address substantive educational problems. The periodic lists of project accomplishments issued by the district reflected a variety of responses to the hypothetical question “How are you continuing to use the opportunity presented to you?” rather than “How are you solving the problems that you wanted to solve through the presence of this grant?” As the project entered its fifth year, the investment of time and commitment dictated a defense of what had been done, thus resulting in a form of organizational cognitive dissonance. ESP was an opportunity that came along at a time when budget cuts were being considered and, as one administrator said, “ESP is such a large grant that it has helped us keep things we were going to cut back.” The slogans evidenced throughout the project reflected the degree to which past structures and practices had transformed the original objectives of the ESP.

### **Summary and Conclusions:**

#### **The Symbolic Aspects of Educational Innovation**

The information provided in this paper, based upon project evaluation documents, fieldnotes, and the project final report (Doyle et al. 1976) illustrates the symbolic aspects of the ESP in Jefferson. The meaning of the project to the people in the schools differed from that signified by the proclaimed rubric of comprehensive change. The slogans about the project reflect its evolutionary history from attempts at integration toward defense of pluralistic autonomy. The direction of this trend assumed increasing importance as the slogans and paradigms of the project became concretized and, in essence, legitimated by an immobilized funding agency.

The ESP was significant not as a project to accomplish comprehensive change but as a project that permitted the district to disrupt only minimally its past traditions and practices. After five years, the ESP had permitted the application of five million dollars in federal funds with much wider discretion than the federal agency originally envisioned—all under the guise of experimentation. While considerable latitude to determine project directions was encouraged originally, OE/NIE believed that this discretion would be used to identify local needs and allow locally supported mechanisms to emerge to meet these needs. Instead, the discretion permitted each school to use the monies for its own preferences, irrespective of district goals or the original intentions of the ESP. The shifting pattern of slogans, reflecting the decentralized nature of the district, was merely an attempt to express as virtues what critics argued were deficiencies. Thus, like many educational innovations, the ESP had minimal effects other than that of infusing large amounts

of money into a locally depressed educational community (Donicht and Everhart 1976). Yet the fact that the sponsoring agency attempted to allow the school district to determine its own program was of value to the federal government, not so much for what was accomplished but rather for that symbolic meaning—federal involvement in local problems in a style compatible with the local community. In this sense, then, the ESP had symbolic value at the national as well as the local level.

The ESP in Jefferson served more a ceremonial than a non-ceremonial function. The slogans used to describe the innovation primarily were responses to external and internal demands, thereby forcing justification for expenditures of funds on isolated change attempts and the continuation of past practices. Few slogans developed to provide the specificity needed to move the project toward implementation of stated goals.

In addressing the implications of symbolism and of slogan systems, an intriguing question centers around the *conditions* under which slogans arise. Specifically, are they omni-present or do they arise chiefly as the result of crucial external factors? We have dealt primarily with the latter case, but we expect that slogans would exist too, albeit in a more stable form, even if the organization was not buffeted by strong environmental forces of an “unusual” type. We believe this because educational “publics” hold a variety of meanings as to what is being done and what should be done; included in this representation is much of symbolic import. Educational programs portray meaning and significance as much in their stability as in their change, and slogans, as representations of particular ideologies, would seem to be present in either case.

We also need to raise the question of the functional use of slogan systems in educational organizations. Most especially, where slogans contribute to the ceremonial function of innovations, they may serve to reconcile the irreconcilable. This certainly was the case in Jefferson where the demands of the NIE, as abstract and ill-defined as they may have been, could not be reconciled with local practice and indeed, the ideologies of most of the educators of the district. The transformation of slogans from those emphasizing integration to those emphasizing autonomy served to stabilize what many perceived as a volatile alliance, characterized by expectations that were unclear at best and conflicting at worse. The slogans that predominated served to justify a “steady state,” yet in a language form required and/or suitable for the ethos of change. After this stability has been achieved, the function of slogans then may shift from one of reconciling the real and the expected to one of defining the program and/or philosophy of the program in relation to other programs/philosophies. Slogans then may come to serve a “boundary defining” function in addition to a reconciling function.

The conditions under which slogans exist and the functions of slogans both inform and are informed by discussions of symbolism in other areas of policy—public housing (Derthick 1972), politics (Edelman 1974), social welfare (Piven and Cloward 1971), deviance (Rothman 1971), community organization (Moore and Meyerhoff 1975), temperance (Gusfield 1959), and health care (Alford 1975), to name a few. Duncan’s (1968) work underlies many of these perspectives. Some work in education also has recognized the symbolic

aspects of educational change: Berman and McLaughlin (1976), Corwin (1973), Cohen (1976), Doyle et al. (1976), House (1974), Popkewitz (1979), and Pincus (1974). However, we need to know more than just the fact that a policy or its operational manifestation has symbolic functions. The antecedents, consequences, and dynamic patterns affecting symbolic representation need careful consideration. We also must ask the question “symbolic for whom?” and recognize the multivariate interpretations that innovations can have—as well as the fact that, as in Jefferson, they may have little meaning at all to some portion of the population.<sup>8</sup>

Finally, the symbolic aspects of educational innovations must be examined in context—that is, as the signs, signals and tokens that people employ to attain personal and group goals.<sup>9</sup> To truly understand these signs, we must recognize how they turn on each other and bequeath new meanings and structures, and not view them (as is the practice in our pragmatic society) as aberrations of a technologically rational ideal. Symbols and slogans are manifestations of meaning and ideologies. We believe that, through an examination of the development and consequences of such meaning, we can gain the leverage to “cut” into the conditions that generate the ethos of educational innovation, an ethos that exists in but is overshadowed by an institution that has been known better for its remarkable stability than for its change. It is for these reasons that analysis of education as a symbolic venture promises so much.

### Endnotes

1. We express particular thanks to our colleagues formerly on the ESEP staff: Donald Eixenberger, Douglas Pierce, and Robert Toepper, who supplied some of the descriptive data on which parts of the paper are based. Edwin Bridges assisted in critical early conceptualizations and themes, and Noah Friedkin and Harry Wolcott provided sound advice on later drafts. This paper was developed from research completed under Contract No. OCE-0-71-4751 with the National Institute of Education.
2. A case in point is the field of classroom management. Many schools have adopted a program called “assertive discipline” with specific rules for behavior and codified consequences for not following those rules. The approach is being touted as “new” and “innovative” and specialists in it are reaping nice fees from conducting district workshops. Yet the approach appears to be little more than an elaborated form of behavior modification emphasizing negative reinforcement for unwanted behavior. Many similar examples exist in the field of instruction, but perhaps one of the best overviews of the “new” forms often being little more than warmed over “old” forms is found in Griffith (1971).
3. For some recent examples of the diversity of interest in change and innovation and examples of focus on the manifest intents of innovations see Herriott and Gross (1978), Metz (1977), and Hornby (1977).
4. “Comprehensive change” never was adequately defined, but generally focused upon changing activities throughout all aspects of the educational system, including not only curriculum and instruction, staffing, and governance, but community involvement as well. All changes were to be such that they “reinforced” each other.
5. Attendance at this first community-wide charette was skewed towards educational professionals: of the fifty-seven people in attendance, forty worked for the district.

6. The reasons for this are complex and beyond the scope of this paper. Generally speaking, the district had a long history of administrative autonomy within the schools, and principals were accustomed to this independence. Also, as we will discuss later, an increase in lump sum budgets to each school heightened the separateness of each school from the district slogans about comprehensiveness and integration.
7. As we note later, one reason for the initial presence of the transiency theme was due probably to the requirement that ESP schools provide resources to the "disadvantaged."
8. Jarvie (1976) notes that symbolic analysis can become misplaced and has been used to excess. We believe, however, that it serves a useful purpose in the analysis of policy, and have yet to apply it to its potential.
9. Two recent books that provide good overviews of symbols and meaning systems are Douglas (1975) and Dolgin, Kemnitzer and Schneider (1977).

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